

Word family: **dark / darker / darkest / darken / darkened / darkening / darkness / darkly**

Base word: dark

Comparative: darker

Superlative: darkest

Part of speech: mainly **adjective** and **noun**

Related forms:

dark (adj.) — 深色的；昏暗的；黑暗的；陰沉的

dark (n.) — 黑暗；暗處

darken (v.) — 變暗；使變暗；使氣氛變沉重

darkness (n.) — 黑暗；陰沉

darkly (adv.) — 陰沉地；帶威脅意味地

dark-haired / dark-skinned / dark-eyed — 深色頭髮 / 膚色較深 / 深色眼睛

dark humour — 黑色幽默

dark side — 黑暗面；負面一面

in the dark — 蒙在鼓裏；不知道情況

after dark — 天黑後

Meaning in this passage

> He usually wore a plain shirt, **dark trousers**, and a pair of glasses.

Here, **dark** means:

having a colour that is closer to black than to white — 深色的；顏色較暗的

The passage is describing the colour of Mr Chan's trousers.

中文翻譯：

他通常穿着簡單的恤衫、**深色長褲**和一副眼鏡。

So here:

dark trousers = 深色長褲

1. **dark colour / clothes** — 深色的

This is the meaning used in your passage.

Practice 1 — original sentence

> He usually wore **dark trousers**.

他通常穿着**深色長褲**。

Practice 2

> She prefers **dark colours** in winter.

她冬天比較喜歡穿**深色系**。

Practice 3

> He wore a **dark blue jacket**.

他穿着一件**深藍色外套**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****dark = 顏色接近黑色、亮度較低的****

2. ****dark hair / eyes / skin — 深色頭髮 / 眼睛 / 較深膚色****

Practice 1

> He has **dark hair** and brown eyes.

他有**深色頭髮**和棕色眼睛。

Practice 2

> She has **dark eyes**.

她有一雙**深色眼睛**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****dark = 頭髮、眼睛或膚色的色調較深****

3. ****dark room / street — 昏暗的；沒有足夠光線的****

A major literal sense.

Practice 1

> The room was too **dark** to read in.

房間太**暗**，看不了書。

Practice 2

> We walked down a **dark street**.

我們沿着一條**昏暗的街道**走。

MCQ-ready definition:

dark = 光線不足、難以清楚看見周圍事物的

4. **get dark / become dark** — 天色變暗；天黑

Practice 1

> It gets **dark** early in winter.

冬天天色很早就**變暗**。

Practice 2

> We should leave before it gets **dark**.

我們應該在**天黑前**離開。

MCQ-ready definition:

get/become dark = 光線逐漸減少，尤其指天色變黑

5. **after dark** — 天黑後

Practice 1

> The park closes **after dark**.

公園在**天黑後**關閉。

Practice 2

> I don't like walking there ****after dark****.

我不喜歡****天黑後****在那裏走。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****after dark = 太陽下山、天已黑之後****

6. ****the dark — 黑暗；暗處****

Here ****dark**** functions as a noun.

Practice 1

> I'm afraid of ****the dark****.

我怕****黑****。

Practice 2

> Something moved in ****the dark****.

有東西在****黑暗中****移動。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****the dark = 沒有光或光線非常少的環境****

7. ****darkness — 黑暗****

Practice 1

> The room was filled with ****darkness****.

房間裏一片****黑暗****。

Practice 2

> They waited until ****darkness**** fell.

他們一直等到****天黑****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****darkness = 沒有光線的狀態****

8. **dark mood / atmosphere — 陰沉的情緒 / 氣氛**

A figurative emotional extension.

Practice 1

> The film has a very **dark atmosphere**.

這部電影有很**陰沉的氣氛**。

Practice 2

> He was in a **dark mood** all evening.

他整晚都處於一種**陰鬱的情緒**。

MCQ-ready definition:

dark = 帶有悲傷、沉重、威脅或不安感覺的

9. **dark story / theme — 黑暗、沉重的故事 / 主題**

Practice 1

> The novel explores some **dark themes**.

這本小說探討一些**黑暗沉重的主題**。

Practice 2

> It's a surprisingly **dark story**.

那是一個出奇地**陰暗沉重的故事**。

MCQ-ready definition:

dark = 涉及痛苦、死亡、恐懼、暴力或人性負面面的

10. **dark humour — 黑色幽默**

Practice 1

> The film uses a lot of **dark humour**.

這部電影用了很多**黑色幽默**。

Practice 2

> His jokes often have a **dark sense of humour**.

他的笑話常帶有一種**黑色幽默感**。

MCQ-ready definition:

dark humour = 以死亡、痛苦、災難等嚴肅或不安題材製造幽默的方式

11. **dark side** — 黑暗面；負面一面

Practice 1

> The documentary shows the **dark side** of fame.

這套紀錄片展示了名氣的**黑暗面**。

Practice 2

> Every industry has a **dark side**.

每個行業都有它的**陰暗面**。

MCQ-ready definition:

dark side = 某人、事物或制度較負面、危險或不願公開的一面

12. **dark secret** — 黑暗秘密；不可告人的秘密

Practice 1

> He had been hiding a **dark secret**.

他一直隱藏着一個**不可告人的秘密**。

Practice 2

> The family had a **dark secret**.

這個家庭有一個**陰暗秘密**。

MCQ-ready definition:

dark secret = 涉及羞恥、傷害、犯罪或其他令人不安內容的秘密

13. **dark thought / thought gets dark** — 陰暗想法

Practice 1

> The conversation took a **dark turn**.

談話開始變得**沉重陰暗**。

Practice 2

> His thoughts became increasingly **dark**.

他的想法變得越來越**陰沉負面**。

MCQ-ready definition:

dark = 思想內容帶有悲觀、危險或令人不安的意味

14. **dark past** — 不光彩 / 陰暗的過去

Practice 1

> The character has a **dark past**.

這個角色有一段**不光彩的過去**。

Practice 2

> The story slowly reveals his **dark past**.

故事逐漸揭露他的**陰暗過去**。

MCQ-ready definition:

dark past = 包含不愉快、羞恥、犯罪或創傷經歷的過去

15. **dark period / dark days — 黑暗時期；艱難時期**

Practice 1

> The country went through a **dark period**.

這個國家經歷了一段**黑暗時期**。

Practice 2

> Those were **dark days** for the family.

那是這個家庭一段**非常艱難的日子**。

MCQ-ready definition:

dark period/days = 充滿困難、悲傷或危機的一段時間

16. **in the dark — 被蒙在鼓裏；不知道情況**

A very important idiom.

Practice 1

> They kept us **in the dark** about the decision.

他們一直把我們**蒙在鼓裏**，沒有告訴我們那個決定。

Practice 2

> I was completely **in the dark**.

我當時完全**不知道發生甚麼事**。

MCQ-ready definition:

be in the dark = 不知道重要資訊或不了解正在發生的事情

17. **keep someone in the dark — 瞞着某人；不讓某人知道**

Practice 1

> Why did you **keep me in the dark**?

你為甚麼一直**瞞着我**？

Practice 2

> Employees were **kept in the dark** about the changes.

員工一直被**蒙在鼓裏**，不知道那些改變。

MCQ-ready definition:

keep someone in the dark = 故意不向某人提供重要資訊

18. **a shot/leap in the dark — 沒有把握的嘗試 / 猜測**

Practice 1

> My answer was really a **shot in the dark**.

我的答案其實只是**沒有把握的猜測**。

Practice 2

> Choosing that option was a **leap in the dark**.

選那個方案其實是一次**沒有把握的冒險嘗試**。

MCQ-ready definition:

a shot/leap in the dark = 在缺乏足夠資訊下作出的猜測或冒險行動

19. **darken (變暗 ; 使變暗) — 變暗 ; 使變暗**

Practice 1

> The sky began to **darken**.

天空開始**變暗**。

Practice 2

> Heavy curtains **darkened the room**.

厚窗簾令房間**變暗**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****darken = 變得更暗，或令某物的光線 / 顏色變暗****

20. ****darken someone's mood / expression — 令情緒 / 神情變沉重****

A figurative extension.

Practice 1

> The news ****darkened his mood****.

那個消息令他的****心情變得沉重****。

Practice 2

> Her expression ****darkened**** when she heard his name.

她聽到他的名字時，神情****沉了下來****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****darken = 令情緒、神情或氣氛變得更沉重、不快或帶威脅感****

21. ****darkly — 陰沉地；帶威脅意味地****

Practice 1

> He spoke ****darkly**** about what might happen.

他****語氣陰沉地****談到可能會發生的事。

Practice 2

> She smiled ****darkly****.

她露出一個****陰沉而令人不安的笑容****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****darkly = 以陰沉、悲觀或帶威脅意味的方式****

22. ****dark horse — 黑馬；出乎意料的有力競爭者****

A very common idiom.

Practice 1

> She could be the **dark horse** of the competition.

她可能會成為這場比賽的**黑馬**。

Practice 2

> The team emerged as a **dark horse**.

這支隊伍成了**出人意料的有力競爭者**。

MCQ-ready definition:

dark horse = 原本不太受注意，但後來可能有出色表現或勝出的參賽者

Important distinction 1: **dark** vs **black**

black

specific colour.

dark

low brightness or deep shade.

> black trousers

黑色長褲

> dark trousers

深色長褲，可能是黑、深藍、深灰等

So in your passage, **dark** deliberately leaves the exact colour unspecified.

Important distinction 2: **dark** vs **dim**

dark

little or no light.

dim

some light exists, but it is weak.

> a dark room

很暗的房間

> a dimly lit room

光線微弱的房間

Important distinction 3: **dark vs gloomy**

dark

can literally mean lacking light or figuratively serious/negative.

gloomy

usually emphasizes sadness, pessimism, or an unpleasant atmosphere.

> a dark corridor

昏暗走廊

> a gloomy mood

陰鬱心情

Important distinction 4: **dark vs deep colour**

Both can describe strong colours.

dark blue

brightness is low.

deep blue

colour is rich/intense.

They often overlap, but **deep** emphasizes richness more than darkness.

Important distinction 5: **dark vs dull colour**

dark

low brightness.

dull

not bright/vivid; may look muted.

A colour can be dark but vivid.

Important distinction 6: **dark-haired vs black-haired**

dark-haired

broader: brown, dark brown, black, etc.

black-haired

specifically black hair.

Same principle as **dark trousers**.

Important distinction 7: **dark mood vs bad mood**

bad mood

irritable/unhappy.

dark mood

heavier and often more serious—sad, bleak, threatening, or deeply negative.

So **dark mood** is usually stronger and more literary.

Important distinction 8: ****dark story vs sad story****

****sad story****

makes you feel sorrow.

****dark story****

may involve:

- * fear
- * violence
- * death
- * moral corruption
- * psychological heaviness

A dark story is not necessarily simply sad.

Important distinction 9: ****dark humour vs cruel humour****

****dark humour****

makes humour from serious/taboo subjects.

****cruel humour****

hurts or mocks people.

Dark humour can be insensitive, but it is not automatically cruel.

Important distinction 10: ****in the dark vs in darkness****

****in the dark****

can mean:

1. literally in darkness
2. figuratively uninformed

****in darkness****

normally literal:

= 在黑暗中

Context matters.

Important distinction 11: ****darken vs dim****

****darken****

make darker generally.

****dim****

reduce brightness, especially light.

> darken the room

令房間變暗

> dim the lights

把燈光調暗

Important distinction 12: ****dark = colour vs dark = lack of light****

These are related but distinct learner senses.

Colour

> dark trousers

深色長褲

Lighting

> dark room

昏暗房間

Something can be ****dark red**** even in bright sunlight.

Important distinction 13: **dark horse** does not mean negative person

The idiom does **not** mean someone evil or mysterious.

It means:

an unexpected competitor with hidden potential

That is a fully lexicalized idiom.

Family-extension note

Dark has a rich but coherent semantic structure built around:

low light / low brightness

From that literal idea, English develops:

1. **colour**

- * dark trousers
- * dark blue

2. **lack of light**

- * dark room
- * after dark
- * the dark

3. **negative emotional tone**

- * dark mood
- * dark atmosphere

4. **serious/disturbing content**

- * dark story
- * dark humour
- * dark secret
- * dark past

5. **lack of knowledge**

- * in the dark
- * keep someone in the dark

6. **figurative idioms**

- * dark horse
- * shot in the dark

7. **change of state**

- * darken
- * expression darkened

These branches are distinct enough for learner-facing treatment while still sharing a recognizable metaphorical core.

Master comparison

Form / expression	Traditional Chinese	Core idea	
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dark trousers	深色長褲	deep colour	
dark blue	深藍色	low brightness	
dark hair/eyes	深色頭髮 / 眼睛	dark colouring	
dark room	昏暗房間	little light	
get dark	天黑	light decreases	
after dark	天黑後	nighttime	
the dark	黑暗	absence of light	
darkness	黑暗	state of no light	
dark mood	陰沉情緒	bleak emotional tone	
dark atmosphere	陰暗氣氛	heavy/threatening tone	
dark story/theme	黑暗沉重故事 / 主題	disturbing content	
dark humour	黑色幽默	humour about grim topics	
dark side	黑暗面	negative aspect	
dark secret	不可告人的秘密	disturbing hidden fact	
dark past	陰暗過去	troubling history	
dark days	黑暗時期	difficult period	
in the dark	蒙在鼓裏	uninformed	
keep X in the dark	瞞着 X	withhold information	
shot in the dark	沒把握的猜測	guess without information	
darken	變暗；使變暗	become darker	
expression darkened	神情沉下來	become negative	
darkly	陰沉地	threatening/bleak manner	
dark horse	黑馬	unexpected contender	

For your original sentence

> He usually wore a plain shirt, **dark trousers**, and a pair of glasses.

Here:

dark = 顏色較深、接近黑色但不一定是黑色的

So **dark trousers** could mean:

- * black trousers
- * dark grey trousers
- * navy trousers
- * another deep-coloured pair

A natural Traditional Chinese rendering is:

> 他通常穿着簡單的恤衫、**深色長褲**和一副眼鏡。

For this passage, **「深色」** is exactly the right sense.